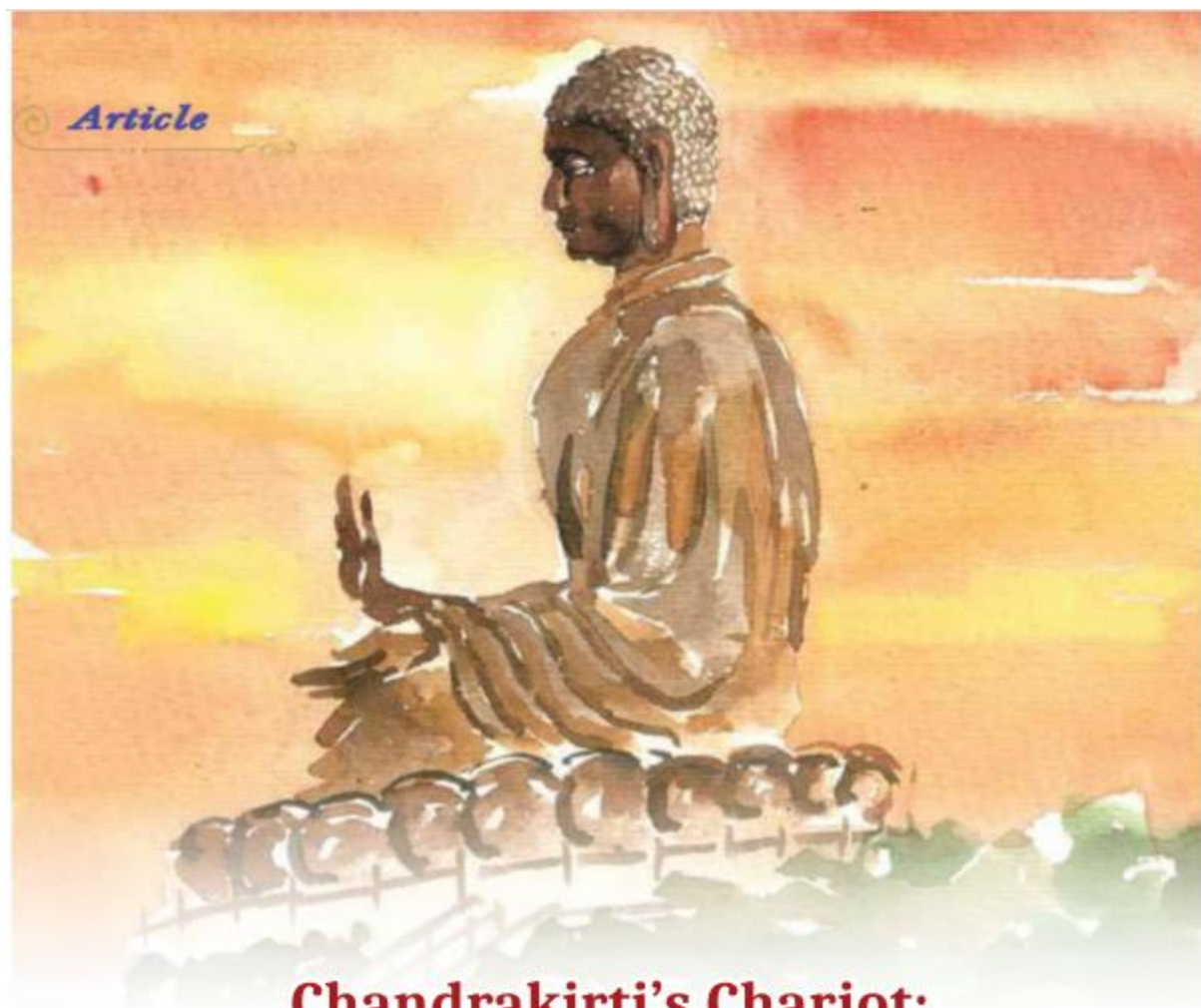




Chandrakirti's Chariot: Self in Madhyamaka Buddhism and Advaita Vedanta

SWAMI SARVAPRIYANANDA

Madhyamaka Buddhism and Advaita Vedanta are among the most important developments of over two millennia of Buddhist and Hindu philosophy. In common with other such systems (*darsanas*), both are soteriological, aiming to overcome suffering. The understandings to which they come about the ultimate nature of the suffering self are sharply different and yet, eerily similar. Both systems continue to exercise a compelling hold on thinkers in the East and increasingly, around

the world. Here we will focus on how the two systems view the self. This paper has three parts. Part one explores the Madhyamaka examination of the self (from sources in Nagarjuna and Chandrakirti, in the light of the millennium-long Tibetan development of Madhyamaka). This will be followed, in part two, by a brief summary of the Advaita concept of the self (*Atman*) and a Madhyamaka examination of the Advaitic Atman. Part three is a comparative reflection on Madhyamaka and Advaita.



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I Madhyamaka Buddhism: The Emptiness of the Self

All Buddhists accept the no-self doctrine but various schools have different accounts of what exactly is meant by no-self. There are degrees of subtlety in the understanding of the self in various Buddhist schools. The Theravada schools usually take it to mean that our sense of self does not refer to anything real: it is a construct which, when analysed, dissolves into the fleeting elemental dharmas. It is the Madhyamikas who offer the most thoroughgoing deconstruction of the self, rejecting the existence of the dharmas as well. The Madhyamaka understanding of the self is based on Nagarjuna's 1st century CE *Mulamadhyamaka Karika*, the discussion on the self is spread across different chapters (especially chapters three and four on the *ayatana*s and the *skandhas*). There is actually a chapter on the self (chapter 18), but it is more concerned with the emptiness of phenomena. In chapter six of Chandrakirti's *Madhyamaka-avatara*, we find the deconstruction of the self in a compact, forensic format. The work of Tibetan thinkers like Mabja, Tsongkhapa, Rendawa, and Mipham is built on Chandrakirti's analysis.

Before we proceed, the ethical basis and purpose of Madhyamaka must be noted. Teachings on the emptiness of the self are given not for the sake of philosophical disputation but for removing the suffering of sentient beings. The root of samsaric suffering is the wrong way of understanding ourselves and the Madhyamaka dialectic seeks to correct that error. The motive is compassion, not winning debates.

Out of compassion, the bodhisattva seeks to free sentient beings from the evil of suffering. This compassion again is of three kinds, with respect to three kinds of objects of compassion—all sentient beings, sentient beings

qualified by impermanence, and sentient beings qualified by emptiness. All three forms of compassion seek to liberate beings from suffering but this third and highest kind of compassion arises from nondual knowledge. Nondual knowledge (free from the duality of the two extremes of permanence and annihilation) arises from the correct application of the Madhyamaka dialectic (as in the seven fold reasoning given later). Without this nondual insight into emptiness, the seeker cannot benefit from the higher Tantric practices leading to Buddhahood.

Tsongkhapa says that one needs three things for enlightenment: 1) altruistic mind, 2) insight into emptiness, and 3) renunciation.¹ Without realising emptiness (of self and phenomena) enlightenment is not possible even if one has both renunciation and altruistic mind. Without enlightenment for himself, how can the bodhisattva enlighten and free others from suffering?

The question is: enlightenment about what? The Buddhist view is that the sufferings of cyclic existence are rooted in the false view about the self. The false view of the self must be corrected—this is enlightenment.

*Perceiving that all faults and all afflictions
Flow from the idea of the transitory composite,*

*And knowing that its focus is the very self
this self is what the Yogi will disprove.*

Madhyamakavatara, 6.120

Taking the self to be the frail body and ever-changing body-mind complex, we suffer from desire, and fear of old age, disease, and death. We cling to what will inevitably pass and die. We try to attain fulfilment by the satisfaction of sensual desires. The wrong beliefs about self are manifested as 'I' and 'mine'. The sufferings can be uprooted if this false view is corrected with the right knowledge. Knowledge

arises from enquiry. This enquiry involves negating the self through reasoning.

The false view is regarding the self as intrinsically existing. There is an instinctive feeling that the self is not merely imputed onto the aggregates, but that it actually exists from its own side. Not only do we instinctively or atavistically feel this, philosophical systems like the Vaisesika and Samkhya go on to reify this instinct into sophisticated Atman theories (Advaita is usually, and incorrectly, lumped in the same category). But such an intrinsically existing self does not exist either conventionally or ultimately, and is the object of negation in the sevenfold reasoning.

There can be two approaches to an understanding of the self: reductionist and non-reductionist. The reductionist understands the self as a construct which can be reduced to (which is nothing more than) a series of events on the body-mind continuum. The Abhidhamma Buddhist account is reductionist; the Atman theories are non-reductionist. The Madhyamaka is also non-reductionist in a different way.

At this point a caveat is needed. We must distinguish between the person and the self. The Buddhist denies the self entirely, but the person is what is reduced to (understandable as) the aggregates. There is a distinction worth noting here. Not all Buddhists are reductionists. Chandrakirti holds the person to be imputed on the aggregates, i.e., the body-mind is the base onto which the notion of person is imputed. In Advaita, the person is taken as the *jiva*, the individual sentient being. In both Advaita and Madhyamaka, the person/*jiva* is admitted at the level of conventional truth.

Atman theories hold the self to be permanent while the aggregates are changing, the self is indivisible while the aggregates are composite, and the self is unitary while the aggregates are multiple. The Sankhya, Yoga,

Nyaya, Vaisesika, and Purva Mimamsa schools hold such views of the Atman. This distinctly metaphysical view of the self is the object of Buddhist critique.

There are Buddhist schools like the Sautrantika, Vaibhasika, and at least some Yogacarins, which too subscribe to some ultimate constituents of the self, like the dharmas or consciousness. Tsongkhapa draws an important distinction between these metaphysical views of the self and the ordinary, conventional view of the everyday self. The Madhyamika criticises the no-self theories of the other Buddhist schools as incomplete and inadequate (Mipham, for example, questions whether the Abhidhamma account is enough to attain freedom from suffering).²

The difference between what is negated and the person is important. In their rush to deconstruct the self, many Buddhist teachers dismiss all notions of the person as illusory. This was not merely a theoretical error but had practical consequences. Tsongkhapa noticed a moral decadence among the monks and traced it back to careless teaching about emptiness. Tsongkhapa, taking his cue from Chandrakirti, defends a robust sense of the conventional. He understood that metaphysical nihilism, epistemological skepticism, and moral relativism go together. Do the objects, people, and other living beings exist at all, or are they all illusion? If all of practical life is mere illusion, then what is the difference between correct knowledge and falsity? Finally, what is the difference between moral and immoral, between dharma and a-dharma and why should one be compassionate towards beings who are no more than figments of imagination? Why should one make the effort to be disciplined, to study, and practice meditation?

By deconstructing the self, Tsongkhapa is not invalidating our commonsense notions of person and identity. It is the metaphysical

reality of the self which is the principal object of critique in Tsongkhapa's deconstruction of the self. Moreover, if conventional reality is to be preserved, then it must be established by valid cognitions. We navigate our everyday world with the help of sensory perception, some form of inferential knowledge and other sources of knowledge. These valid cognitions are generated by a set of epistemic instruments whose warrant is admitted by Tsongkhapa (following Chandrakirti's coherentist account of *pramana*).

In any case, the person that is imputed on the basis of the aggregates and which is useful for daily activities, is not denied at the conventional level. This person is not found under ultimate analysis and so is said to be empty. But that does not interfere with ordinary affairs. Chandrakirti's seven-fold reasoning, using the metaphor of the chariot, negates an inherently existing self in verses 120-150 of the *Madhyamakavatara* (but not a person; in verses 151 onwards he guards against nihilism regarding the person). The no-self doctrine holds that -

- 1) The existence of an eternal and independent self is an illusion
- 2) There is no need to posit such a self to explain our experiences.
- 3) Personal identity can be understood by the five aggregates; there is no self beyond these aggregates.
- 4) Grasping at the self is the root of *samsara* and suffering.
- 5) Negation of the self is the path to spiritual freedom (*Nirvana*) from suffering.³

The Sevenfold Reasoning:

The basic argument is that if a self inherently existed it would have to be either different from the body-mind aggregates, or the same as the aggregates, and since the self is neither, it does not exist inherently. Chandrakirti elabo-

rates this basic argument into the seven-fold reasoning on the analogy of the chariot, which goes like this:

- 1) Just as the chariot is not the same as its parts such as wheels, spokes etc., so too the self is not the same as the body-mind aggregates.
- 2) Just as the chariot is not different (independent) from its parts, so too the self is not different (independent) from the aggregates.
- 3) Just as the chariot is not contained by its parts, so too the self is not contained by the aggregates.
- 4) Just as the chariot is not the substratum upon which its parts depend, so too the self is not the substratum upon which the aggregates depend.
- 5) Just as the chariot is not the possessor of its parts, so too the self is not the possessor of the aggregates.
- 6) Just as the chariot is not the mere collection of its parts, so too the self is not the mere collection of the aggregates.
- 7) Just as a chariot is not the shape or configuration of its parts, so too the self is not the shape of the aggregates (specifically, the form aggregate, as the other aggregates have no physical shape anyway).

First, Chandrakirti considers the possibility that an independent self exists apart from the aggregates. This would be the view of the dualistic Hindu schools like *Nyaya*, *Vaisesika* and *Sankhya*. Chandrakirti suggests that such an eternal self is unborn like a barren woman's child.⁴ Being unchanging it can have no relation with, or act, upon the aggregates. It would be useless in explaining self-clinging. It would not explain memory, karma, and rebirth. Being un-arisen, such a self would be simply non-existent. Note that this Chandrakirti draws upon Buddhist metaphysics of momentariness and causal efficacy, which the non-Buddhist schools do not subscribe to.

The second alternative is that self is nothing other than the aggregates. After all, there is no chariot apart from its parts either. There are however several objections to identifying the self with the aggregates.

Objection 1: Redundancy of the concept of the self⁵

If the self is identical to the aggregates, then there remains no ontological difference between the body-mind and the purported self. The term 'self' becomes an empty label with no unique referent.

Objection 2: The absurdity of multiple selves

Our intuition of the self is that it is unitary, indivisible, and enduring. But the aggregates are complex, divisible and momentary. If the self is identical to the multiplicity that constitutes the aggregates, the implication is that there are many selves. This is absurd – nobody thinks of themselves as a committee of many selves!

Objection 3: The collapse of the law of karma

If the self and the ever changing aggregates be the same, then there is no persisting identity over time. One may act in a certain way at a point of time, and not reap the results of that action which arise much later. At that later point of time, the original person is no longer there – it is a different self/bunch of aggregates.

Conversely, the 'new' selves arising over time would inherit the results of actions they have not committed. This is the twin fault of *krita naasha* and *akrita praapti* – 'the loss of karma already done, and the suffering of karmic results of actions not done'. Of course, as Thupten Jinpa points out, one need not buy into the theory of karma to see the problem. It

could be as simple a matter as inability to contradict oneself – for one would be different from the earlier self who made the contradicting statement.

Objection 4: Impossibility of memory

The aggregates being momentary, the self too becomes momentary. There is nothing to connect the continuum. Then one could not genuinely remember something from the past, as the body-mind which experienced that event are not the same as the body-mind where recollection is attempted. One self experienced something and it is quite another which would remember. Chandrakirti actually argues against this Buddhist idea of a continuum of independent momentary entities, each producing the next. If something arises from a cause intrinsically different from it, then anything could produce anything. The continuum of Devadatta might as well produce entities in the continuum of Dharmadatta.

Objection 5: Conflating the agent and object of action

We have an intuitive owner-owned relationship with the aggregates and their functions. The aggregates we feel, are owned, and I am their owner, as in 'my body is overweight', 'I am seeing' etc. Yet, this relationship becomes impossible if the self is identical with the aggregates. I become the owner and owned at the same time, or even the agent as well as the object of action simultaneously. The very concepts of action, act, and agent become meaningless.

If there is no eternal, independent self apart from the aggregates, and if the self cannot be identified with the aggregates, then what constitutes the self? The five remaining alternatives would be variations of the identity in difference model. They would be open to one or more of the same difficulties arising in

either differentiating the self from the aggregates or identifying the self with them. The third alternative is that, self is something that contains the aggregates ('like juniper berries placed on a metal tray' comments Mipham on verse 142). Since the self and aggregates are not different entities, it is idle to even entertain such a possibility. The fourth alternative is the opposite – that the self may be contained by the aggregates – and this is again rejected because the self and aggregates are not distinct entities. The next alternative is that the self is the possessor of the body-mind. This is rejected because the non-existent self cannot possess anything ('meaningless to talk of the physique of the childless woman's son' says Mipham on verse 143). The sixth alternative is the self as a collection of its parts. The chariot cannot simply be the collection of parts, as it is no longer a chariot upon dismantlement (although the parts are still there). Similarly, there is no self to be found in the collection of aggregates. Finally, could the chariot be the configuration of parts—an emergent shape?

Could the self emerge from a particular configuration of aggregates? But the new shape (chariot) is not the shape of individual parts, nor when the parts are arranged (for parts do not change shape). Emptiness of the self is the result of the sevenfold reasoning. But this is not a negation of the conventional person. Chandrakirti is not nihilistic about the person.

Chandrakirti is remarkable in the way he grounds abstruse philosophical disputation in the ordinary experience of the common man (cowherd!). In verse 140, he clarifies a possible misunderstanding. It may be thought that the Buddhists are claiming when a permanent self (like say, the one propounded by Sankhyas) is disproved, ego-clinging with all its attendant afflictions will be overcome. Nothing could be further from the truth. Ego-clinging ('I' and 'mine') is not rooted in the belief of a philosophical permanent self. Banishing the permanent self will not erase ego-clinging – one might as well see a nest of snakes and try to find safety in the thought 'There are no elephants, so there is no cause of fear!'

(To be continued...)



References

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- 3) Thupten Jinpa, *Self, Reality and Reason in Tibetan Philosophy* (London: Routledge Curzon, 2002), p. 70.
- 4) Chandrakirti, *Madhyamaka Avatara*, verse 122.
- 5) Thupten Jinpa, *Self, Reality and Reason in Tibetan Philosophy* (London: Routledge Curzon, 2002), pp. 87-91



II. Advaita Vedanta: The Self as the Absolute

The goal in Advaita Vedanta is the cessation of suffering and the attainment of true fulfillment. Suffering, according to this school, is due to ignorance of the true nature of the self and consequent erroneous identification with the body-mind. The body-mind are taken to be the self and their inherently unstable and incomplete nature gives rise to desire. Action done in the pursuit of desire binds us in karmic consequences, which generate repeated births and deaths. Correction of this error of identifying the self with body-mind will lead to cessation of desire, action and the results of actions (the cycle of repeated births and deaths), thus delivering us from suffering.

The Advaita Vedanta claim about the self can be summarised briefly. The real nature of the self (Atman) is said to be pure being (*Sat*), pure consciousness (*Chit*) and pure bliss (*Ananda*) – the Absolute (*Brahman*). Being,

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(Continued from the previous issue ...)

consciousness, and bliss are not the attributes of the Absolute but its very nature. Brahman is nondual – there is no second reality apart from It. Brahman is infinite i.e., not limited by time or space. Even though Atman is identical with Brahman, the term Atman is not superfluous as it is not enough to know that there is Brahman. Enlightenment is the Realisation that the self (Atman) is the Absolute (Brahman). It is of the form, 'I am Brahman' (*Aham Brahmasmi*).

The Buddhist approach is to investigate our uncritical preconceptions (as well as philosophical reifications) of the self, to show that the self is free of intrinsic existence, and thus dissolve ignorance, desire and suffering. In Advaita, the goal is pretty much the same – the dissolution of ignorance, desire and suffering – but the method is different. It is helpful to ask, 'What is it that we are ignorant of?' The object of ignorance in Buddhism is emptiness of self (and phenomena) while in Advaita, the object of ignorance is the Absolute nature of the self (and phenomena).

The Advaitic enquiry proceeds in two steps. First, we are led to see that the body-mind complex cannot be the self, that the true self must be distinct from the body-mind (which is still an entirely dualistic position),



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and then, second, the true self is shown to be the Absolute and nonduality is established. It must be noted here that the methodology is necessarily grounded in the Upanishads as Advaita Vedanta claims to be nothing more than an elucidation of the Upanishads.

The Realisation of the self as Brahman is accomplished through philosophical enquiry (*vichara*). There are various modes of this enquiry – the discernment of the seer and the seen (*drig drishya viveka*), the analysis of the three states of waking, dreaming, deep sleep (*avastha traya viveka*) and the analysis of the five sheaths (*pancha-kosha viveka*) are prominent. They are all various species of phenomenological analysis of our daily experience. The first one operates on the principle that seer and the seen must be different entities – the world, body, and mind are all ‘seen’ i.e., experienced by me. So, I the seer (experiencer) must be different from, and witness of the body-mind. The second approach is based on the experience of waking-dreaming-deep sleep. By noting the changing nature of the three states and their contents, and the unchanging nature of the experiencer of the three states (‘I alone experience waking, dreaming and deep sleep’), one comes to the understanding of the self as the unchanging witness of the three states. Similarly, the method of the five sheaths analyses the human personality into five sheaths – the physical, the vital, the mental, the intellect and the ‘bliss sheath’ – and shows how the self is none of the five sheaths but their unchanging witness.

One is invited to notice that body changes continuously while the self is intuited to persist. The mind is even more unstable, while the self endures. Again, the body and mind are objects (the ‘seen’) while the self is always the ‘seer’, never the ‘seen’. It is helpful to think what Chandrakirti would make of this. In the Madhyamaka approach, the ‘seer’ and the ‘seen’

would be mutually dependent, the very concepts of ‘seer’ and ‘seen’ evoking each other. Why should we take one, the seer-self to be independent? The Advaitin would reply that while the term ‘seer’ and ‘seen’ are certainly mutually dependent, ontologically the self exists along with its capacity of ‘seeing’ – just that this is not evident in the absence of the seen object. The reason is that the absence of an object is seen as much as its presence. Otherwise, how could one speak of the absence of an object? The seer-self is present while the seen-object may be present or absent. Hence, we can speak of the seer-self as independent.

To go on with the analysis, the self is where we feel conscious and that which we are conscious of, is the non-self. Applying this criterion (call it sentient vs insentient) I notice that the external world, our bodies and even our innermost feelings and ideas are all objects to my consciousness (‘I am aware of them, they are not aware of me’).

Two central tenets of Advaita are that consciousness is indubitably revealed to me in first-person and it never becomes an object. Even to doubt consciousness requires consciousness. Shankara observes, ‘He who doubts this Self, It is the Self of that very doubter!’ And if consciousness becomes an object, to what is it an object?⁶

For all of these reasons – enduring vs. non-enduring, seer vs. seen, sentient vs. insentient – we awaken to the Realisation that the real self cannot possibly be the body-mind. These reasons should be taken as persuaders like legal arguments, not as strictly logical demonstrations of the existence of a self distinct from body-mind. There are many such suggestive ‘pointers’ found in Advaitic literature. A good sampling of six such pointers is found in this single verse from the *Aparokshanubhuti* (Direct Realisation), a text attributed to Shankara –

Even the subtle body consists of many parts and is unstable. It is also an object of awareness, is ever changeable, limited and false by nature. So how can it be the Self?

(*Aparokshanubhuti*, verse 39)

But this is only the first stage of a two step approach to the not-two. After labouring to establish a self distinct from the body-mind, the Advaitin quickly negates this distinction. In the same text, verse 41, Shankara says,

Thus asserting a self distinct from the body-mind only serves to establish the reality of the phenomenal world (duality), in the manner of the (dualistic) Tarkashastra. But what ends of human life (*purushartha*) are served thereby?

This movement in the Advaita argument is central to this paper. At this point, Shankara and Chandrakirti are in agreement – there is no entity called a self distinct from the aggregates. The Sankhya/Yoga, Nyaya/Vaisesika and other schools which assert such an Atman are dismissed by both Chandrakirti and Shankara for almost similar reasons. The difference is important however. Shankara agrees that the Atman is not a distinct entity apart from the aggregates, but he goes on to claim the Atman is the foundational reality of the appearance of the aggregates (and all else besides). Chandrakirti does not assert this, but nor does he explicitly deny it. This is not an alternative examined by the seven-fold reasoning.

At this second step, the revised claim now is that it is not true that there exist bodies, minds and countless external entities apart from the Atman. All the varieties of gold ornaments do not exist apart from gold nor do the endless waves in the ocean exist apart from water. Similarly, bodies, minds and everything else do not (and cannot) exist apart from the Atman. Since Atman is being itself, to be apart from Atman is tantamount to non-existence.

Shankara gives several such analogies to show that Atman is foundational for the world appearance.⁷ He does not advance independent arguments in support of this key movement, preferring scriptural justification instead. However, an independent argument might be construed in the following manner.

If the Atman (consciousness) is the unchanging witness of the not-Atman (body-mind and the world), what is the relationship between Atman and not-Atman? Are the Atman and non-Atman two independent entities, capable of separate existence? By the method of presence and absence, one can show that this is impossible. Two entities are said to be independent of each other if the presence of one can be demonstrated in the absence of the other. Thus a pot and a cow are independent as each can be seen to exist without the other. But, nothing can be ‘demonstrated/proved’ in the absence of consciousness. It is consciousness which vouches for the presence/absence of its objects. So the separate, independent existence of the not-Atman can never be proved. The presence (and absence) of body-mind (and the world) are experienced only in consciousness. It is, in principle, impossible to prove that the not-Atman exists by itself.

This dependent existence characterizes the world and every entity within it (including our body-mind complexes). Since the world is not a countable second apart from the Atman, the Atman is nondual (without a second). The nondual Atman, which is now understood as the witness and ontological ground of the world appearance, is called Brahman. This is the grand identity of Atman and Brahman proclaimed in Upanishadic statements like ‘That thou art’,⁸ ‘I am Brahman’,⁹ and ‘This very self is Brahman’.¹⁰ The existence, illumination and

value of every entity depends on the Brahman, because Brahman is being, consciousness, and bliss (Sat-Chit-Ananda).

The logic of taking two steps to arrive at this understanding is that until identification of the body-mind as the self is negated, and the true nature of Atman intuited, there is no possibility of the nondualistic Realisation. Asserting a self distinct from body-mind is purely pedagogical, and not meant to be a metaphysical claim. In fact, one must move onto to the next step (nonduality) otherwise there is no hope of gaining release from suffering (*moksha*) which is the goal (*purushartha*).

The world exists dependently on Brahman and that which has no intrinsic existence is not truly existent. So the world is not truly existent and yet not utterly non-existent like the son of a barren woman. The world is only name and form (*nama/rupa*) or, as the Chhandogya Upanishad puts it, the world has only nominal existence (*vacharambhanam vikaro namadheyam*).¹¹ This is the meaning of 'false' in the Advaitic doctrine of 'Brahman alone is real, the world is false, and the sentient being is really none other than Brahman' (*Brahma satyam, jagat mithya, jivah Brahmaiva na aparah*).

The Madhyamaka dialectic is directed against entities with intrinsic existence. The world and body-mind aggregates have no intrinsic existence – we see that the Madhyamika and the Advaitin agree on this in conclusion, if not in method. Now the question arises, does the Advaitin claim that Brahman has intrinsic existence? If so, this would immediately be a target for the Madhyamaka dialectic. But not only does the world have no intrinsic existence; neither does Brahman! If an entity exists by itself, independently, without regard to any other entity, it is said to have intrinsic existence. The Advaitic absolute is not to be regarded as an entity with intrinsic existence, an item among

other items (the world is full of items with no intrinsic existence, Brahman is a distinct entity with intrinsic existence – not so). Brahman is pure being, which is conceptually distinct from entities which enjoy dependent existence. Entities of the world, including bodies and minds, are however not ontologically distinct from Brahman. They are identical with Brahman in the ontological sense that a golden ornament is identical with gold. But, Brahman is no more a special kind of entity than gold is (by itself) a special kind of ornament. It cannot be a target of the Madhyamika dialectic.

Just like Madhyamaka, Advaita maintains a two-truths ontology and epistemology. Nagarjuna's ultimate truth (*paramartha satyam*) and conventional truth (*samvriti satyam* or *vyavaharika satyam*) correspond to the Advaitin's *paramartha satyam* and *vyavaharika satyam* (the same Sanskrit terms are used). This is neither by accident nor coincidence. Both systems claim to be nondualistic and reject duality as illusion. Since the appearance (and utility) of duality cannot be denied by anyone, a two-tier paradigm of truth becomes inevitable. 'By implication every absolutism has to formulate the distinction of reality and appearance and the two truths ...'¹²

In Madhyamaka as in Advaita, one cannot realise the ultimate truth without recourse to the conventional truth. The scriptures, the spiritual path, the practice and its results are all within *vyavahara* in both systems. Again, in both systems, the two truths are not about two separate realities, rather they are two truths about one and the same reality. Samsara and Nirvana are identical in both. Language is strictly limited to the conventional and cannot denote the ultimate, in both systems (though language may 'point at' what cannot be said).

Incidentally, Advaita actually maintains a four-realities ontology (1. *Paramarthika* – ulti-

mate truth – Brahman, 2. *Vyavaharika* – relative reality – the world and its contents 3. *Pratibhasika* – illusions, fiction or error – dream objects, snake in rope etc, and 4. *Tuccha* – total non-existence – barren woman's son, square circle etc).

We are now in a position to reconsider Chandrakirti's chariot from an Advaitic perspective. What does the seven-fold reasoning do to the Advaitic Atman/Brahman?

1) The Atman is not the same as the body-mind aggregates. In the first step of Advaitic enquiry, we saw with what care the Atman is distinguished from the body-mind. But the dialectic which works well against the dualistic Hindu schools like Nyaya/Vaisesika or Sankhya/Yoga does not get traction here. The dualistic schools hold the body-mind and self to be distinct and equally real entities, a claim which is difficult to defend in the face of the Madhyamaka dialectic. Both the Madhyamaka and the Advaitin reject a separate and independently existing self. However, there are differences – Chandrakirti is content to deny but Advaita goes on to assert that, the body-mind are not truly separate from the nondual Atman, as they borrow not only illumination but also their very existence from the Atman. Bodies and minds are appearances in the Absolute, which is the Atman. Further, it is by enquiry into the very experience of the body-mind that the Atman can be discerned.

2) Just as the chariot cannot be found apart from its parts, the self is not different (independent) from the aggregates. Chandrakirti goes on to show why the self cannot be identical with the aggregates either. As we saw earlier, Advaita is in full agreement that the self cannot be identical to the body-mind, but goes on to claim that the self is immanent in the body-mind as their very existence and illumination. The body-mind are dependent on the Atman. Do the five objections raised in the first

part of this writeup apply to this mode of existence of the self? The redundancy objection does not apply as Atman does refer (in a special sense) uniquely to the existence-consciousness which is the fundamental reality of the body-mind. The contingency of multiplicity of selves does not arise, because the Atman is not identical with the body-mind aggregates, rather they are dependent on the Atman. The objections based on Karma do not apply because the Atman is anyway beyond Karma. Karma applies to individual sentient being (*jiva*) which is the Atman under conditions of ignorance. Karma is upheld for 'selves' but not for the 'Self'. The objection from impossibility of memory does not apply as it is based on momentariness to begin with. Even if momentariness be admitted, Advaita does not use the Absolute to explain the unity of memory. It is the *jiva* (relative self) which does the heavy-lifting as far all empirical functions (like memory) are concerned. Finally, the objection from conflation of agent and object of action does not apply either as the 'owner-owned' relationship is strictly an intuition at the relative truth level. At the level of ultimate truth, non-duality does not admit action, agent, object or 'owner-owned'.

3) Just as the chariot is not contained by its parts, so too the self is not contained by the aggregates. The Atman is not contained by the body-mind in any sense.

4) Just as the chariot is not the substratum upon which its parts depend, so too the self is not the substratum upon which the aggregates depend. This is a tricky one because it could apply to the Atman as the substratum of the body-mind. The 'substratum' or 'ground' is a fair translation of the Sanskrit *adhara*. But the Absolute is the substratum/ground of the world appearance. There are actually not two, the ground and that which is held up by the ground (which is what Chandrakirti is refuting

here). Rather a kind of supervenience is meant (the exact term is *adhyasa*, which means 'taking what is not there, to be there'). If there were two, the aggregates and the self supporting the aggregates, dialectic would apply and the refutation would be appropriate. But, the Advaitin is claiming nonduality – the Atman is the substratum of appearances, much as the rope is the substratum of the snake appearance. The aggregates are appearances, the Atman alone is real (and so is not ultimately, a substratum either).

5) Just as a chariot is not the possessor of its parts, so too the Atman is not the possessor of the aggregates. The nondual Atman does not have any real relationship with anything (since no second entity exists apart from the Atman). How then is the atman associated with the person, the *jiva*? The Advaita response would be at two levels. One, at the level of ultimate truth, *paramartha satya*, the Advaitin would flat out deny there is actually a *jiva* – or anything else – with which the nondual Absolute can be related. There can be no talk of relations in nonduality. Two, at the level of relative truth, *vyavaharika satya*, the *jiva* is a superimposition (*adhyasa*) on the Absolute. The *jiva*, and all associated duality of subject-object, appears in the Absolute without violating the nonduality of the Absolute. The term 'appears' is crucial; like trees reflected in water, or to take a modern equivalent, a movie on a screen – there is an appearance of duality and action, where really

there is only the water or the movie screen. For practical purposes, difference, action and its results, linguistic usage etc. are all admitted but, from the ultimate point of view, there is only the nondual Atman.

6) Just as the chariot is not the mere collection of its parts, so too the Atman is not the mere collection of the aggregates. The Atman as understood in Advaita is indivisible and not a collection.

7) Just as a chariot is not the shape or configuration of its parts, so too the Atman is not the shape of the aggregates. Advaita does not claim the Atman somehow emerges from particular configurations of the body-mind.

Chandrakirti's project was to show that the seven alternatives exhaust all the reasonable ways in which the self may be conceived to exist. None are rationally possible, hence there is no self. Yet, Chandrakirti has nowhere considered the concept of self as pure being/pure consciousness. There is no direct refutation of such an alternative in the seven fold reasoning. Indeed, if we are to venture further afield into the broader Yogachara-Madhyamaka, some support for such a possibility can be discerned. In any case, the Advaitic Atman/Brahman slips through the net and survives as a plausible conception of the self (though a very different self than the dualistic substance theories of Atman presented by Samkhya, Nyaya and other opponents against whom Chandrakirti's dialectic is aimed).

(to be concluded ...)



References

- 6) *Kena Upanisad*, 1.3–1.9. The theme of Chapters 1 and 2 of the Upanishad is the non-objectifiable nature of the self.
- 7) Shankaracharya, *Aparokshanubhuti*, trans. Swami Vimuktananda (Kolkata: Advaita Ashram, 2013), 45–55 for scriptural basis and 59–88 for various analogies.
- 8) *Chhandogya Upanishad*, 6.8.7.
- 9) *Brihadaranyaka Upanishad*, 1.4.10.
- 10) *Mandukya Upanishad*, 2.
- 11) *Chhandogya Upanishad*, chapter 6.
- 12) T R V Murti, 'Samvrti and Paramartha in Madhyamika and Advaita Vedanta', in *The Problem of Two Truths in Buddhism and Advaita Vedanta*, ed. Mervyn Sprung, (Boston: D Reidel, 1973), p.9.

Chandrakirti's Chariot: Self in Madhyamaka Buddhism and Advaita Vedanta

SWAMI SARVAPRIYANANDA

(Continued from the previous issue ...)

III. Emptiness and the Absolute

The Hindu and Buddhist schools were engaged in debate for over a thousand years. The debates produced a rich philosophical literature in Sanskrit and led to increasingly sophisticated metaphysics, epistemology, and logic. The existence of the self was one of the two central issues debated (the other was the existence of God). Broadly speaking, the Hindu thinkers invariably characterised the Buddhists as nihilists while the Buddhists held their opponents to be substantialists (upholders of intrinsic existence—eternalism). This holds true when we narrow our focus to Advaita Vedanta and Madhyamaka.

Incidentally, the terms *advaya* and *advaita* have been used by the proponents of Madhyamaka and Advaita Vedanta to describe their systems, but too much should not be read into this terminological similarity. Though both terms are translated as 'nonduality', they actually differ in their meaning. The Madhyamaka *advaya* means freedom from the duality of the two extremes of 'is' and 'is not' (eternalism and nihilism). In Advaita Vedanta, nonduality means the identity of the individual sentient being (*jiva*) and the Absolute (*Brahman*) – it means the absence of difference (*bheda*).

For Nagarjuna and Chandrakirti, the principal Hindu opponents were the Nyaya/

Vaisesika, the Sankhya and the Purva Mimamsa (along with assorted Buddhist schools). Advaita Vedanta made a late appearance and was classified along with the others as another species of substantialist eternalism. Some later Buddhist thinkers (in India and later in Tibet) recognize the affinity of Advaita thought with their own (usually with the Yogacara) and take special care to distinguish themselves from Advaitins.

Traditional Advaitins mostly dismiss Madhyamaka on the grounds of nihilism. Shankara for example refutes Madhyamaka with a curt, 'As for the view of the absolute nihilist, no attempt is made for its refutation since it is opposed to all means of valid knowledge. For human behaviour, conforming as it does to all right means of valid knowledge, cannot be denied so long as a different order of reality is not realised; for unless there be an exception, the general rule prevails.'¹³ The standard 14th century manual of Advaita, Vedantasara (which is used to introduce Advaita to beginners) says the Madhyamaka holds the self to be *asat* (absolutely non-existent).¹⁴ This seems deeply unfair. Nagarjuna and Chandrakirti clearly state that they are not nihilists. The very term 'Middle Way' is a negation of both extremes of nihilism and eternalism.

One must add, however, that a survey of the Tibetan commentarial literature shows commit-



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ted Madhyamakas regularly accusing each other of falling into the error of nihilism. One of the ways in which Prasanga (reduction to the absurd) can be deployed is to push the opponent into a position which entails either nihilism or eternalism. If such subtle shifts of position among Madhyamakas themselves can readily entail nihilism, one may take a charitable view of the Advaita charge of nihilism against Madhyamaka.

On the Advaita side there were a few philosophers who acknowledged the affinities of the two systems. Sri Harsa¹⁵ (11th century CE) readily takes the Madhyamaka position against his Nyaya opponent, while Vidyanaya (14th century CE) briefly considers conditions under which the two systems can converge. It is also instructive to note that the dualistic schools of Vedanta, fiercely opposed to Advaita, regularly deprecated Advaitins as pseudo-Buddhists (*prachhanna bauddha*). The school of Vaisnavite Vedanta in Bengal, traceable to Sri Chaitanya, speaks direly of two schools of *Mayavada* – one from Gaya (Buddhism) and one from Banaras (Advaita) – both reprehensible!

When we come to contemporary thinkers, there are a number of noted Indian philosophers who see clear affinities between Advaita and Madhyamaka. Surendranath Dasgupta sees Shankara's Brahman as very much like Nagarjuna's Sunya. He opines, 'It is difficult indeed to distinguish between pure being and pure non-being as a category ... I am led to think Shankara's philosophy is largely a compound of Vijnanavada and Sunyavada Buddhism with the Upanishad notion of the permanence of the self superadded.'¹⁶ TRV Murti is more subtle, but comes to similar conclusions holding that Nagarjuna does not actually deny reality, he denies all views about reality. His dialectic clears the jungle of views, opening the (presumably mystic) way to the Absolute. This approach towards reconciling Madhyamaka with Advaita would

benefit from a clear statement from Nagarjuna or Chandrakirti – 'We deny all views about reality, but not reality itself.' They however, are not cooperative! These modern thinkers seem to take it for granted that Nagarjuna is an Absolutist, who just won't admit it outright.

In recent decades, a lot of work has been done on Madhyamaka by modern scholars, both in terms of translation of Tibetan works into English and philosophical reconstruction. The state of the art understanding of Madhyamaka is to see Nagarjuna, through Chandrakirti and the Tibetan tradition, as antifoundationalist metaphysically and coherentist epistemologically. Here is Jay L. Garfield on Madhyamaka epistemology: 'in what must be the first explicit defense of epistemological coherentism in the history of world philosophy, (Nagarjuna argues) that these instruments are themselves useful and authoritative precisely because they are dependent.'

From the Madhyamaka perspective, Advaita seems metaphysically extravagant. Why demand grounding in an Absolute when all can be explained without such a ground? For the Madhyamika, the dialectic is philosophy. The *prasanga reductio* arguments refute all views and there is nothing further to know. For the Advaitin, the dialectic refutes duality or difference (*bheda*) and leads to the realisation of the nondual Atman as the real self – not a new knowledge but a realisation of what was always the case.¹⁷ The nondualism Madhyamaka is epistemological, aiming at freedom from conceptual distinctions, while the Advaita nondualism is ontological.¹⁸ From an Advaitic perspective, the Madhyamaka account looks incomplete. Consider the following. Nagarjuna says in his *Precious Garland of Advice for the King* (31, 32):

*Just as without depending on a mirror
An image of one's face is not seen
So also, there is no I
Which does not depend on the aggregates.*

The analogy is curiously incomplete. In the analogy there are actually three elements – the mirror, the reflected face *and* the real face. Nagarjuna is of course perfectly within his rights to deploy the analogy the way he wants but we are left with the temptation to ask, ‘But what about one’s real face – the one which is reflected in the mirror?’ The mirror and reflected face analogy is used by Advaita too. The mirror is the aggregates as before (specifically the mind) and the reflected face represents an apparent self (specifically *Chidabhasa* – appearance of consciousness) whereas the real face is the real self, *Chit* (pure consciousness).

Both systems make ample use of imagery, metaphors and analogies. The difference in the choice of analogy is revealing: Chandrakirti’s sheaves of hay leaning against each other versus Shankara’s snake-rope. One is antifoundationalist while the other points to a foundational reality. In the sixth chapter of the *Madhyamaka Avatara*, Chandrakirti does confront the foundationalism of the Yogacara school (who posit a consciousness continuum as the ground of appearance). The Yogacarin holds that there cannot be illusion without a ground of appearance. While Chandrakirti does a thorough job of demolishing the proposal that mind only could be such a ground, he does not in the end seem to have responded to the original concern. Can there be appearance without ground, magic without the magician and dreams without a dreamer?

The picture painted by the *Madhyamaka* might be acceptable to the Advaitin as an adequate characterisation of *Maya*, the network of the world appearance. But, the Advaitin would then insist that it has to be grounded in the Abso-

lute. Nagarjuna and Chandrakirti would beg to differ. And we reach an impasse. It is helpful to regard these systems as *upayas* – skillful means – to soteriological goals, and not as rival metaphysical systems. In both, we notice the teachings are meant to be discarded once enlightenment is attained. In both, philosophy is therapeutic and the end is the same – an end to suffering.

Conclusion

It would seem that philosophers like Dasgupta, Murti and others were well-intentioned but misled in seeing the *Madhyamaka* as a variety of Absolutism. But when we widen the focus from the strict Geluk Prasangika-*Madhyamaka* to include Sakya, Nyingma, Kagyu and the Jonang views, this clarity is diffused and questions arise again. If we further incorporate Tibetan Tantra and the practical aspects of Tibetan Buddhism, the picture is naturally complicated. A full appreciation of the ultimate *Madhyamaka* understanding would necessarily have to take into account the internal dynamics of philosophy and practice, *Madhyamaka* and Tantra, within the great monastic schools of Tibetan Buddhism.

However, it goes without saying, that the Indo-Tibetan *Madhyamaka-Yogacara*, and the Advaita traditions remain enormous resources to be mined in the search for answers to the original big questions which have new forms in our age. Faced with the hard problem of consciousness, and the ever receding and vanishing ground of material nature, we would be wise to turn to ancient answers to modern questions: What is the nature of consciousness? What is existence? What is philosophical truth? *

(Concluded.)

References: 13) See Shankaracharya, *Brahma Sutra Bhasya*, trans. Swami Gambhirananda; 14) Sadananda Yogindra, *Vedantasara*, trans. Swami Nikhilananda (Kolkata: Advaita Ashram, 2014), pp.95–96; 15) P. E. Granoff, *Philosophy and Argument in Late Vedanta: Sri Harsa’s Khandana Khanda Khadyam*, pp. 84–110, Granoff details how Sri Harsa openly takes the *Madhyamaka* position against Nyaya; 16) Surendranath Dasgupta, *History of Indian Philosophy*, I:493–94; 17) T R V Murti, p. 11; 18) T R V Murti, p. 13.